

eFOOTBALL AND FIFAE RANKINGS GIVE INDIA FRESH HOPE

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In a country where gaming primarily resides on mobile screens, India's esports identity is beginning to reflect a trend. A fleeting World No. 6 ranking in 2023 hinted at potential, only ending in heartbreak at the 2022 Asian Games.

Three years on, a sustained presence near the top in eFootball Mobile, alongside steady progress in Rocket League, suggests India may finally be playing to its strengths.

In the FIFAE World Rankings, introduced by the International Football Association (FIFA) last month, India appears in the top 10 of eFootball mobile rankings and in the top 20 of Rocket League.

The disparity in eFootball rankings — sixth in mobile to 59th in console — and India's impressive 17th rank in Rocket League — third-best in Asia — have two notable indicators: FIFA's diversification allows more global representation for the country, and India playing to its strength in a mobile-first market.

India has taken giant strides in Rocket League at the Asian level, qualifying for the Commonwealth Esports Championships three years ago and then reaching the semifinals of the FIFAE World Cup regional qualifiers, where it lost all games to Australia.

In FIFAE's first-ever rankings, India — with 1108.40 points — is the third-best Rocket League team in Asia, after Jordan (1209.19 points) and Saudi Arabia (1632.00 points). In eFootball mobile, India earned valuable ranking points through Danial Shakeel Patel ([in pic](#)), who reached the semifinals of last year's FIFAE World Cup. Danial's rise comes at a time when the Asian Games will have eFootball mobile for the first time.

Konami, the game's publisher, said in a statement: "eFootball™" will be used in the soccer game genre, and a new mobile division will be added to this year's competition in addition to the console division, bringing the total to two divisions.'

The 2026 edition of the Asian Games, scheduled in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan, between September 19 and October 4, will be only the second time the continental showpiece will have esports as a medal event, and will have the following titles:

Street Fighter 6; Tekken 8; The King of Fighters XV; Pokémon Unite; League of Legends; PUBG Mobile (Asian Games Version); Puyo Puyo; Naraka: Bladepoint; eFootball —console and mobile; Gran Turismo.

India — through the Esports Federation of India (ESFI) — plans to select athletes for at least eight of the titles between March 7 and the first week of April. The selected athletes will advance to the Asian regional qualifiers, scheduled between May and July 2026.

A SILENT SMILE FOR GAMERS AT COMIC CON CHENNAI

The not-so-glamorous end of gaming is that of a lasting generation gap between aspiring gamers and parents oblivious to the world of console and mobile games. At the Chennai Comic Con, held on February 14 and 15, the razzmatazz at the Trade Centre saw the sombre take the backseat and childhood play the hero. Joel, a seven-year-old, was busy racing on an F1 simulator. His father, standing right behind him, wasn't worried, but proud.

"The exposure here is amazing. If this is what gaming offers for Joel, I'm all in," he tells Sportstar with a smile.